

Eyewitness Trap Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and the Knower • 15-20 min

Category	Knowledge and the Knower	Time	15-20 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	eyewitness-trap

Big idea: Memory is reconstructive, not photographic.

Overview

Students see that memory is often reconstruction rather than playback.

Student Prompt

Inspect Eyewitness Trap Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Eyewitness Trap Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A busy classroom image followed by questions about colours, positions, and text. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Eyewitness Trap Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: A short silent hallway scene with one misleading follow-up question. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Eyewitness Trap Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A confidence-versus-accuracy table for memory claims. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Memory is reconstructive, not photographic.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Eyewitness Trap Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Eyewitness Trap Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	When should memory be trusted as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how memory is reconstructive, not photographic.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: A busy classroom image followed by questions about colours, positions, and text.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- A busy classroom image followed by questions about colours, positions, and text.
- A short silent hallway scene with one misleading follow-up question.
- A confidence-versus-accuracy table for memory claims.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Show a busy image for 10 seconds.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Remove it and ask factual questions: colours, objects, positions, text, number of people.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Ask students to rate their confidence in each answer.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Reveal the image and compare accuracy with confidence.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat perception or memory as a recording device.
- Students may assume confidence is evidence rather than a feeling about evidence.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Separates perception, memory, belief, confidence, and justification.
- Uses the activity result to make a cautious claim about knowers.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Short lesson: use only the first example, one response grid, and one debrief question.
- Long lesson: add a second round where students revise the method and compare outcomes.
- Low-tech option: run with printed cards, sticky notes, and a board tally.

Extension Tasks

- Design a second version of the activity that tests the same knowledge issue in another AOK.
- Find a real-world example where the same knowledge problem matters outside the classroom.
- Write a 150-word TOK exhibition-style commentary using the activity as the object context.

Related Activities

- Change Blindness Starter
- Confidence Calibration Test
- Personal Knowledge Map